Standing in the Gap

Like Abraham, we are invited to pray boldly and humbly for others, appealing to God's justice and mercy, because God delights to hear the prayers of his friends.

Main passage	Genesis 18:20-33 (KJV)
Topic	Intercession
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: God shares his heart with his friends	7 min
Teaching point 2: Pray on the basis of God's character	7 min
Teaching point 3: Bold, humble and persistent	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "Has anyone ever prayed for you during a hard time, and you knew it made a difference?" Let a few people share. Then ask: "Whom do you pray for regularly?" Today we watch Abraham pray for a whole city, and we learn what it means to intercede.

Scripture (3 min)

Genesis 18:20-33

[20] And the LORD said, Because the cry of Sodom and Gomorrah is great, and because their sin is very grievous; [21] I will go down now, and see whether they have done altogether according to the cry of it, which is come unto me; and if not, I will know. [22] And the men turned their faces from thence, and went toward Sodom: but Abraham stood yet before the LORD.

[23] And Abraham drew near, and said, Wilt thou also destroy the righteous with the wicked? [24] Peradventure there be fifty righteous within the city: wilt thou also destroy and not spare the place for the fifty righteous that are therein? [25] That be far from thee to do after this manner, to slay the righteous with the wicked: and that the righteous should be as the wicked, that be far from thee: Shall not the Judge of all the earth do right? [26] And the LORD said, If I find in Sodom fifty righteous within the city, then I will spare all the place for their sakes. [27] And Abraham answered and said, Behold now, I have taken upon me to speak unto the Lord, which am but dust and ashes: [28] Peradventure there shall lack five of the fifty righteous: wilt thou destroy all the city for lack of five? And he said, If I find there forty and five, I will not destroy it. [29] And he spake unto him yet again, and said, Peradventure there shall be forty found there. And he said, I will not do it for forty's sake. [30] And he said unto him, Oh let not the Lord be angry, and I will speak: Peradventure there shall thirty be found there. And he said, I will not do it, if I find thirty there. [31] And he said, Behold now, I have taken upon me to speak unto the Lord: Peradventure there shall be twenty found there. And he said, I will not destroy it for twenty's sake. [32] And he said, Oh let not the Lord be angry, and I will speak yet but this once: Peradventure ten shall be found there. And he said, I will not destroy it for ten's sake. [33] And the LORD went his way, as soon as he had left communing with Abraham: and Abraham returned unto his place.

Read the passage aloud, with readers for Abraham and the LORD.

Background (5 min)

In Genesis 18, three visitors came to Abraham's tent. One of them is identified as the LORD himself. After promising Abraham and Sarah a son, the LORD revealed his plan to judge Sodom and Gomorrah, whose wickedness was very great. Abraham's nephew Lot lived in Sodom.

God said, "Shall I hide from Abraham that thing which I do?" (18:17). Abraham is later called "the Friend of God" (James 2:23). Friends share their plans, and here God invited Abraham into a conversation about justice and mercy.

Teacher note: In the end, ten righteous people were not found, but God rescued Lot and his daughters (Genesis 19:15-16, 29). Genesis 19:29 says God "remembered Abraham," so Abraham's prayer was answered in a way he had not exactly asked.

Teaching point 1: God shares his heart with his friends (7 min)

Intercession begins with God. He told Abraham what he was about to do, and Abraham "stood yet before the LORD" (v. 22). Prayer for others grows out of knowing God and hearing his word. When we read Scripture and see the world through his eyes, we are moved to pray.

Supporting verses

Genesis 18:17-22 (read from the Bible)

John 15:15: Henceforth I call you not servants; for the servant knoweth not what his lord doeth: but I have called you friends; for all things that I have heard of my Father I have made known unto you.

Amos 3:7: Surely the Lord GOD will do nothing, but he revealeth his secret unto his servants the prophets.

> *"Communion with God is kept up by the word and by prayer. In the word God speaks to us; in prayer we speak to him."*
>
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Genesis 18:23-33

Handout blanks (answers)

Abraham stood yet before the **LORD**.

Prayer for others grows out of knowing **God**.

Teaching point 2: Pray on the basis of God's character (7 min)

Abraham did not appeal to his own goodness. He appealed to God's: "Shall not the Judge of all the earth do right?" (v. 25). He was confident that God would not treat the righteous like the wicked. The best intercession reminds God of who he is: just, merciful and faithful to his promises.

Supporting verses

Genesis 18:23-25: And Abraham drew near, and said, Wilt thou also destroy the righteous with the wicked? Peradventure there be fifty righteous within the city: wilt thou also destroy and not spare the place for the fifty righteous that are therein? That be far from thee to do after this manner, to slay the righteous with the wicked: and that the righteous should be as the wicked, that be far from thee: Shall not the Judge of all the earth do right?

Exodus 32:11-14: And Moses besought the LORD his God, and said, LORD, why doth thy wrath wax hot against thy people, which thou hast brought forth out of the land of Egypt with great power, and with a mighty hand? Wherefore should the Egyptians speak, and say, For mischief did he bring them out, to slay them in the mountains, and to consume them from the face of the earth? Turn from thy fierce wrath, and repent of this evil against thy people. Remember Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, thy servants, to whom thou swarest by thine own self, and saidst unto them, I will multiply your seed as the stars of heaven, and all this land that I have spoken of will I give unto your seed, and they shall inherit it for ever. And the LORD repented of the evil which he thought to do unto his people.

Psalm 145:8-9: The LORD is gracious, and full of compassion; slow to anger, and of great mercy. The LORD is good to all: and his tender mercies are over all his works.

> *"God alone is the Judge of all men."*
>
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Genesis 18:25

> *"an invariable principle of justice, that the righteous shall not be punished for the crimes of the impious"*
>
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Genesis 18:23

Handout blanks (answers)

Shall not the **Judge** of all the earth do right?

Good intercession appeals to God's **character**.

Teaching point 3: Bold, humble and persistent (7 min)

Abraham asked again and again: fifty, forty-five, forty, thirty, twenty, ten. He was bold enough to keep asking, and humble enough to say, "I ... am but dust and ashes" (v. 27). God never grew impatient; he agreed each time. Abraham cared about people who were far from God, and he did not give up.

Supporting verses

Genesis 18:26-33 (read from the Bible)

Luke 18:1: And he spake a parable unto them to this end, that men ought always to pray, and not to faint;

1 Timothy 2:1-4: I exhort therefore, that, first of all, supplications, prayers, intercessions, and giving of thanks, be made for all men; For kings, and for all that are in authority; that we may lead a quiet and peaceable life in all godliness and honesty. For this is good and acceptable in the sight of God our Saviour; Who will have all men to be saved, and to come unto the knowledge of the truth.

> *"showing in an unmistakable manner the efficacy of prayer and intercession"*
> — Robert Jamieson, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Genesis 18:23

> *"Though sin is to be hated, sinners are to be pitied and prayed for."*
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Genesis 18:23-33

Handout blanks (answers)

I have taken upon me to speak unto the Lord, which am but **dust** and ashes.

Sin is to be hated, but sinners are to be **pitied** and prayed for.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. Why do you think God told Abraham about his plans for Sodom?

Because Abraham was his friend and covenant partner; God wanted to draw him into prayer and teach him about justice and mercy.

2. What do we learn from the way Abraham argued with God?

We may pray boldly and honestly, reasoning from God's own character, while remaining humble.

3. Abraham prayed for a wicked city. How does that challenge whom we pray for?

We should pray for people far from God, even those we disapprove of, not just friends and family.

4. How was Abraham's prayer answered, even though Sodom was destroyed?

God rescued Lot and his family because he "remembered Abraham" (19:29).

Application (3 min)

Make an intercession list this week: two family members, two friends, two people far from God, and your town or nation. Pray for each by name every day. Be specific, appeal to God's goodness, and do not give up.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Lord, thank you that you share your heart with your people and invite us to pray. Make us intercessors like Abraham: bold because you are good, humble because we are dust, and persistent because we care. We pray for our families, our friends, our neighbours and our nation. Judge of all the earth, have mercy, for Jesus' sake. Amen.

Sources quoted

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Genesis 18:23-33

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Genesis 18:25

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Genesis 18:23

Robert Jamieson, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Genesis 18:23

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